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The lesser-known apostles

Faithful names on the list: James son of Alphaeus, Judas (Thaddaeus), Simon the Zealot, and Matthias.

Every list of the Twelve ends with a few names we know almost nothing about. James the son of Alphaeus is never quoted. Judas, "not Iscariot," asks Jesus one question at the last supper. Simon is remembered only by his label, "the Canaanite" or "Zelotes," which probably marks him as zealous for Israel's cause. After the resurrection Matthias is chosen to take the place of Judas Iscariot. These men were sent out with the same authority as Peter and John. Their place on the list reminds us that most of Christ's servants work without fame.

At a glance

<i>James son of Alphaeus</i>	Ninth in every list; possibly "James the less" (Matthew 10:3; Mark 15:40)
<i>Judas, not Iscariot</i>	Also Thaddaeus; "Judas the brother of James" (Luke 6:16)
<i>Simon the Zealot</i>	"The Canaanite" (Matthew 10:4) and "Zelotes" (Luke 6:15)
<i>Matthias</i>	Chosen by lot to replace Judas Iscariot (Acts 1:23–26)
<i>Main passages</i>	Matthew 10:2–4; Mark 3:16–19; Luke 6:14–16; John 14:22; Acts 1:13–26
<i>Later lives</i>	Not recorded in Scripture; see Tradition on page 4

"And he ordained twelve, that they should be with him, and that he might send them forth to preach."

Mark 3:14, KJV

The life of The lesser-known apostles

Dates are approximate (AD). Jesus' ministry is dated c. AD 27/28–30 in this study, and the crucifixion c. AD 30. Scripture gives no ages.

- c. AD 28

On a mountain

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Chosen as apostles

After a night of prayer, Jesus chooses twelve from among his disciples. James son of Alphaeus, Judas and Simon are named among them. *Luke 6:12–16*
- c. AD 29

Galilee

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Sent out two by two

Jesus gives the Twelve power over unclean spirits and sends them to preach repentance, heal the sick, and anoint with oil. *Mark 6:7–13; Matthew 10:1–15*
- c. AD 30

The last supper

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Judas asks a question

Judas, "not Iscariot," asks why Jesus will show himself to the disciples and not to the world. Jesus speaks of love, obedience and his dwelling with them. *John 14:21–23*
- c. AD 30

Jerusalem

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Wait in the upper room

After the ascension James, Judas and Simon pray with the other apostles, the women, and Jesus' mother and brothers. *Acts 1:13–14*
- c. AD 30

Jerusalem

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Matthias is chosen

Peter calls for a witness of the resurrection to replace Judas Iscariot. After prayer the lot falls on Matthias, who is numbered with the eleven apostles. *Acts 1:15–26*

Group notes

Key activities

The names in the lists differ slightly. Most readers take Thaddaeus, Lebbaeus and "Judas of James" as one man known by more than one name. Luke's Greek says only "Judas of James," so he may be James's son rather than his brother; the KJV supplies "brother."

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- 1 Were chosen by Jesus.** Each was named an apostle after Jesus prayed all night. *Luke 6:12-16*
 - 2 Shared the mission.** They were sent with power to heal and to preach the kingdom of God. *Luke 9:1-6*
 - 3 Asked about Jesus' self-revelation.** Judas asked, "Lord, how is it that thou wilt manifest thyself unto us, and not unto the world?" *John 14:22*
 - 4 Held on after the cross.** They stayed together and continued in prayer with one accord. *Acts 1:13-14*
 - 5 Stepped into an empty place.** Matthias, who had been with Jesus since John's baptism, became a witness of the resurrection with the eleven. *Acts 1:21-26*
 - 6 Received the Spirit.** All the apostles were together on the day of Pentecost, and Peter stood up "with the eleven." *Acts 2:1-4, 14*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names these apostles.

Old Testament

Psalm 69:25; 109:8	Applied by Peter to Judas's empty place (Acts 1:20)
Proverbs 16:33	The lot is cast, but the LORD decides
Echo: Genesis 49:28	Twelve apostles, like Israel's twelve tribes
Echo: Numbers 25:11–13	Phinehas, zealous for his God, like Simon's title

New Testament

Matthew 10:2–4; Mark 3:16–19; Luke 6:14–16; Acts 1:13	The four lists
John 14:22; Acts 1:23–26	Judas asks his question; Matthias is chosen
Matthew 19:28; Revelation 21:14	Twelve thrones and twelve foundations
Tradition	Simon and Jude are said to have died in Persia

For discussion

- Observe:* According to Mark 3:14, what were the Twelve chosen for?
- Understand:* What did the church look for in Judas's replacement (Acts 1:21–22)?
- Apply:* These apostles served with little recognition. Where are you serving unnoticed, and how can you keep at it?
- Apply:* A zealot and a tax collector served together. Who very different from you could you work with or pray for?